

ENG508 SHORT HANDOUTS

MIDTERM

Lesson 06 to 10

(ENG508) Semantics and Pragmatics

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Lesson 06

MEANING, THOUGHT AND REALITY

Topic 28: Sense and Concepts

What is the role of sense in language and thought?

Sense is a mental representation that links words and the real world.

How does sense relate to the concept of resemblance?

The relationship between sense and the real world is one of resemblance.

How can the word "triangle" have different senses for different speakers?

Different speakers may have various mental images of triangles based on their experiences.

What modification is made to the image theory regarding the sense of some words?

It's hypothesized that the sense of some words is not visual but more abstract.

What is the role of sense in language and thought?

Sense plays a crucial role in bridging the gap between language and thought. It represents a level of mental representation that links words to the real world. In other words, it allows us to understand and conceptualize the meaning of words by associating them with mental images or representations. This connection between words and mental representations is fundamental in understanding how we convey and comprehend meaning through language.

Topic 29: Necessary and Sufficient Conditions

What is the traditional approach for describing concepts?

Necessary and sufficient conditions are used to describe concepts.

What are necessary conditions in the context of concepts?

Necessary conditions are attributes that something must have to be considered an example of a concept.

What are sufficient conditions in the context of concepts?

Sufficient conditions are the right set of conditions that define a concept fully.

Topic 30: Prototypes

How is the model of concepts as prototypes structured?

Concepts are structured with central, typical members and less typical or peripheral members.

How do experiments support prototype theory?

Speakers tend to agree more readily on typical members, which come to mind more quickly.

What is the essence of the prototypical conception of categories?

The prototypical conception emphasizes typical members and the gradient nature of categories.

How is the model of concepts as prototypes structured?

The model of concepts as prototypes is structured in a way that acknowledges the existence of central or typical members within a category, such as "BIRD" or "FURNITURE." In this model, there are central members that are considered highly typical and representative of a particular category. These central members gradually transition into less typical or peripheral members, which do not exhibit all the typical characteristics but still belong to the same category.

Topic 31: Linguistic Relativity

Who are the key figures associated with the notion of linguistic relativity?

Edward Sapir and Benjamin Lee Whorf are associated with linguistic relativity.

What does linguistic relativity propose regarding language and thought?

It suggests that the language we speak conditions our conceptualization and is influenced by culture.

Topic 32: The Language of Thought Hypothesis

Why do proponents of cognitive science reject linguistic relativity?

Cognitive science rejects linguistic relativity and argues that thinking can occur without language.

What is the "language of thought hypothesis"?

It posits that cognitive processes use a separate computational system in the mind, a "language of thought."

How do proponents of the "language of thought" view the relationship between thought and spoken language?

They believe that we think in a language of thought (Mentalese) and translate it into spoken language when needed.

Lesson 07

Lexical Relations - I

Topic 33: What Are Lexical Relations?

What is the branch of semantics that deals with word meanings called?

Lexical semantics.

How would you define lexical relations?

Lexical relations are relationships of the meanings of words to other words.

What types of relations do lexical relations encompass, aside from semantic relations?

Lexical relations include phonetic relations such as rhyme and alliteration, morphological relations such as inflectional variations, and morpho-syntactic relations such as co-membership in a grammatical category.

What does the term "lexical relation" encompass, and how does it differ from just a semantic relation?

The term "lexical relation" includes phonetic relations like rhyme and alliteration, morphological relations such as inflectional variations, and morpho-syntactic relations like co-membership in a grammatical category. It goes beyond just semantic relations and contributes to the network-like structure of our mental lexicon.

Topic 34: Words and Lexical Items

What is the focus of interest in semantic relations?

Lexemes or semantic words.

How do words differ in their representation in different linguistic levels (writing, phonology, syntax)?

Words can be identified in writing by white spaces, in phonology as strings of sounds, and in syntax, they can have various grammatical variations.

What is a lexeme in semantics?

A lexeme is the same semantic word represented by several grammatically distinct variations.

Topic 35: Problems with Pinning Down Word Meaning

What makes it difficult to define word meanings?

The influence of context on word meanings.

What is "collocation," and how does it affect word meanings?

Collocation is the tendency for words to occur together repeatedly, and it can restrict and influence word meanings.

How do contextual effects pull word meanings in two opposite directions?

They can lead to both restriction (collocation) and creativity (semantic shift) in word meanings.

What is the challenge with word meanings regarding ambiguity and vagueness?

It is often challenging to determine whether a word exhibits ambiguity or vagueness.

Explain the concept of "collocation" and how it affects word meanings.

Collocation refers to the tendency of words to occur together repeatedly. This can influence word meanings by restricting the words they commonly appear with. For example, "strong tea" and "powerful car" have different collocations, leading to variations in meaning.

Topic 36: Homonymy and Polysemy

What are homonyms, and how are they different from polysemous words?

Homonyms are unrelated senses of the same phonological words, whereas polysemous words have related senses under the same lexical entry.

Can you give an example of homonyms with the same syntactic category and the same spellings?

"Lap" - 'circuit of a course' and "lap" - 'part of the body when sitting down.'

How are polysemous words identified?

Polysemy is identified based on the criteria of "relatedness" between different senses.

Topic 37: Synonyms and Antonyms

What is synonymy in the context of word meanings?

Synonymy is the notion of sameness of meaning.

How can you define synonyms?

Synonyms are different phonological words with the same or very similar meanings.

What is a common characteristic of synonyms?

The substitution of one synonym for another does not change the truth value of a sentence.

What are antonyms?

Antonyms are words that are opposite in meaning.

What are simple antonyms, and how do they relate to each other?

Simple antonyms are complementary pairs where the negative of one implies the positive of the other.

Name and explain one other type of antonym relationship mentioned.

Gradable antonyms, where the positive of one term does not necessarily imply the negative of the other.

Lesson 08

Lexical Relations II

Topic 38: Hyponymy

What is hyponymy?

Hyponymy is a relation of inclusion.

Give an example of hyponymy.

Dog and cat are hyponyms of 'animal'.

What is the more general term in hyponymy called?

The more general term is called superordinate.

Explain the concept of "inclusion" in hyponymy.

Inclusion means that if an object is a hyponym of another word, then it is necessarily included in the meaning of the more general term.

Topic 39: Meronymy

Define meronymy.

Meronymy is a part-whole relationship between lexical items.

Provide an example of meronymy.

"A page is part of a book" illustrates meronymy.

How do meronyms vary in terms of necessity to the whole?

Meronyms can vary in how necessary the part is to the whole. Some are necessary (e.g., nose as a meronym of the face), others are usual but not obligatory (e.g., collar as a meronym of the shirt), and some are optional (e.g., cellar for the house).

How does meronymy differ from hyponymy in terms of transitivity?

Meronymy may or may not be transitive, whereas hyponymy is always transitive.

Topic 40: Causative Verbs and Agentive Nouns

What do causative verbs identify?

Causative verbs identify a relationship between an adjective describing a state and a verb describing a beginning or change of state.

Provide an example of a causative verb.

"Widen" is a causative verb in the sentence "The City Council widened the road."

What is the role of agentive nouns?

Agentive nouns have the meaning of "the entity who/which performs the action of the verb."

Give an example of an agentive noun.

"Skier" is an agentive noun.

What is the relationship between causative verbs and adjective-verb combinations, and can you provide an example?

Causative verbs relate to adjective-verb combinations by indicating a change of state. For instance, 'wide' in 'the road is wide' corresponds to 'widen' in 'the road

widened.' In the latter, 'widen' is a causative verb, signifying the action that leads to a change in the state of the road.

Explain the role of agentive nouns and provide examples.

Agentive nouns signify the entity or person who performs the action of a verb. One common type of agentive noun is formed from verbs and often ends with '-er' or '-or.' Examples include 'skier,' 'walker,' 'whaler,' 'toaster,' 'commentator,' 'dictator,' and 'calculator.'

Topic 41: Colour Terms

How did Berlin and Kay investigate color terms in languages?

Berlin and Kay investigated that languages vary in the number and range of their basic color terms.

What criteria define a basic color term?

Basic color terms are monolexemic, not hyponyms of other colors, have wide applicability, and are not a semantic extension of something manifesting that color.

How many basic color terms does English have in its system?

English has eleven basic color terms in its system.

How many basic color terms does the English language have in its system?

The English language has eleven basic color terms in its system: 'white,' 'black,' 'red,' 'green,' 'yellow,' 'blue,' 'brown,' 'purple,' 'pink,' 'orange,' and 'grey.'

Topic 42: Core Vocabulary and Universal Lexemes

What is core vocabulary in a language?

Core vocabulary consists of more frequent and basic words widely used in a language.

Who originally proposed a 200-word list of core vocabulary?

Swadesh originally proposed a 200-word list of core vocabulary.

What are universal lexemes, and how are they established?

Universal lexemes are words that are claimed to be common across all languages. They are established through in-depth analysis of individual languages and rely on reductive paraphrase in natural language.

What do proponents of universal lexemes claim about the semantic primes of all languages?

Proponents claim that the semantic primes of all languages coincide, suggesting lexical universals.

Lesson 09

Lexical Semantics: Fields and Collocations

Topic 43: Introduction

What is the concept of 'value' in Saussure's linguistic theory?

'Value' in Saussure's theory refers to how a word's identity is derived from its relational function, not its inherent qualities.

How did Saussure emphasize the relational aspect of language?

Saussure emphasized that language is based on differences and that meanings of words are associated with other words through various relations like collocation and sense relations.

What does Saussure's linguistic theory mean by the concept of 'value'?

In Saussure's linguistic theory, the concept of 'value' signifies that a word's identity isn't determined by its inherent qualities like shape or size. Instead, a word is defined by what it can do in relation to other words in the language. For

example, a "knight" on a chessboard is called a "knight" because of its function in the context of the game, not because of any inherent characteristics.

Topic 44: Paradigmatic and Syntagmatic Relations - I

What are paradigmatic relations in linguistics?

Paradigmatic relations are associations between words of the same grammatical category that can be substituted for each other without affecting sentence structure.

How is a paradigm defined in linguistic terms?

A paradigm is a set of linguistic units that can replace each other within a sequence or structure without disrupting sentence syntax.

What is the 'vertical axis' of selection in linguistic terms?

The 'vertical axis' of selection refers to the substitution of words with others sharing the same grammatical function, preserving sentence structure.

Can you explain the concept of the 'vertical axis' of selection in linguistics?

The 'vertical axis' of selection in linguistics is a term often used to describe the paradigmatic dimension of language. It refers to the process of selecting one word or unit from a set of possible choices that could fill a particular slot in a sentence. For example, in the sentence "The cat was sitting on the rug," the word "the" can be replaced with other words like "a," "their," "his," and "my," demonstrating this vertical selection process.

Topic 45: Paradigmatic and Syntagmatic Relations - II

What are syntagmatic relations in language?

Syntagmatic relations are associations between words co-occurring in a sequence, forming syntagms like phrases or sentences.

How does the arrangement of units in a sentence affect its meaning?

The arrangement of units in a sentence along the syntagmatic axis (horizontal) influences its meaning.

Can you provide an example of syntagmatic relations in a sentence?

In "red car" and "green car," "red" and "green" are in syntagmatic relation with "car."

Can you provide an example of syntagmatic relations in a sentence?

Certainly, in the sentences "I write what I know" and "I know what I write," the same units, "I," "write," "what," and "know," are present. However, the arrangement of these units along the syntagmatic system (the 'horizontal' axis) is different, resulting in distinct meanings for each sentence.

Topic 46: Semantic Fields

How do semantic fields vary across cultures?

Semantic fields vary based on culture and can denote segments of reality symbolized by related words.

What is a common characteristic of words within a semantic field?

Words in a semantic field share a common semantic property and are used to discuss the same general phenomenon, but they are not synonymous.

Topic 47: Collocations

What is a collocation in language?

A collocation is a frequent co-occurrence of words that represent a fully grammatical structure or a combination conveying meaning through association.

How did Firth describe understanding a word?

Firth stated that "you shall know a word by the company it keeps," highlighting the importance of collocation in understanding words.

Topic 48: Idioms

What are idioms in language?

Idioms are expressions whose meaning cannot be deduced from the individual meanings of their components and often require specific translations.

Can idioms be replaced with equivalent words or phrases?

Idioms cannot be replaced with semantically or syntactically equivalent words or phrases.

Provide examples of idiomatic expressions.

Examples of idiomatic expressions include "kick the bucket," "fly off the handle," and "red herring."

Lesson 10

Sentence Relations and Truth

Topic 49: Logic and Truth

What did Montague (1974) hypothesize about the use of logic in representing sentence meaning?

Montague hypothesized that logic can help represent sentence meaning.

Where does the study of logic originate from, and what is its primary focus?

The study of logic originates from the Classical Greek world, primarily Aristotle, and focuses on the principles of valid argument and inference.

How is truth defined in the context of this lesson?

Truth is defined as a correspondence with facts or the correct description of states of affairs in the world.

Is truth generally empirical, and why?

Yes, truth is generally empirical because it depends on the facts of the world to determine whether a statement is true or not.

Provide an example illustrating empirical truth.

Example: "My father was the first man to visit Mars." The truth of this sentence depends on whether the speaker's father actually went to Mars and was the first man there.

Topic 50: Propositional Logic

What is another name for propositional logic?

Propositional logic is also known as "propositional calculus" and "sentential calculus."

What does propositional logic focus on?

Propositional logic focuses on the relations that hold between sentences, irrespective of the internal structure of the sentences themselves.

How is a sentence's truth or falsity described in propositional logic?

A sentence's truth or falsity is described based on its truth value, and the facts required to make it true or false are called its truth conditions.

Provide an example of how propositional logic can be applied to determine the truth of one sentence based on another.

Example: "John is in his office" and "John is at home." If the second sentence is false, it can be concluded that the first sentence is true.

Topic 51: Predicate Logic

Why was predicate logic developed, and what does it handle that propositional logic cannot?

Predicate logic was developed to handle the truth behavior of sentences with quantifiers (e.g., "all," "every," "some") and can handle inferences that depend on relations within sentences. This is something propositional logic cannot do.

How is predicate logic related to propositional logic?

Predicate logic is not wholly distinct from propositional logic but includes it because it deals with relations between sentences as well.

How is a statement like "John loves Mary" symbolized in predicate logic?

"John loves Mary" may be symbolized as $L(a, b)$, where L stands for the predicate "loves," and (a) and (b) represent "John" and "Mary."

Topic 52: Entailment

How is entailment defined by truth?

Answer: Entailment is defined by truth as "a sentence p entails a sentence q when the truth of p guarantees the truth of q , and the falsity of q guarantees the falsity of p ."

Provide an example of entailment.

Example: "The anarchist assassinated the emperor" (a) entails "The emperor died" (b).

How does entailment differ from typical inference?

Entailment is not a typical inference; it doesn't require reasoning to get from the first sentence to the second; it's an instantaneous recognition based on knowledge of the language.

Topic 53: Truth Conditional Semantics

What is the central idea behind truth conditional semantics?

The central idea is that knowing the meaning of a sentence involves knowing the conditions under which it is true.

Who proposed a definition of a true sentence and how does it relate to meaning?

Tarski proposed that "a true sentence is one that states the state of affairs as they are." This concept can be converted into a theory of meaning.

Explain the distinction between object language and meta-language.

Object language refers to the language being discussed (e.g., English sentences), while meta-language refers to what is said about the object language. They may share some words but serve different purposes.

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